Fat Shaming: The Other Side

By Kathy Appelt, Georgia Me, Rachel Wiley and Melissa May

INTRODUCTION

All people are created equal—that is, unless they're fat. Although overweight and obesity affect two-thirds of Americans, overweight people are presumed lazy, undisciplined, dishonest and unintelligent. In fact, 61% of our population see no harm in making negative remarks about a person's weight. But now, overweight people are speaking out against fat shaming. This compilation is called Fat Shaming: The Other Side and features poems by Kathy Appelt, Georgia Me, Rachel Wiley and Melissa May.

The Fat Girl by Kathy Appelt

She's already reached into
her backpack four times
in fifteen minutes.

Four times, silently
at her metal desk against the wall,
she's slipped her hand
into the bright blue canvas pouch.

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No one sees her, hears her
open the cellophane bags of
Twinkies, M&M's, Chee-tos
her true companions.

Ever since they forgot her real name
somewhere around the fifth grade
she's certain
she's become invisible.

Without her real name
to identify her, then
who's to say she took
the missing peanuts
and crème-filled Oreos?

She thinks someday she'll shed
this skin she wears in layers
and float away
    down a river
    on a cloud
but right now it's all she can do

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to stay away from that backpack.

Right now she's trying hard

to find her real name

sew it on her left pocket

in threads above her heart

so no one will forget again.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kathi Appelt
Book: Poems from Homeroom
ISBN: 978-0805075960
Publisher: Owlet Paperbacks
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier – MS

INTRODUCTION

Our society views thinness as a symbol of hard work, self-discipline and willpower—values we have come to revere above all else. So people who are overweight are simply lacking in self-discipline, right? Did you know that two in five women say they would trade three to five years of their lives to achieve their ideal weight? But the reality is that many causes of obesity are beyond the individual's control.

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-- genetics, economic status, upbringing and the way parents talk to their children about weight all have a bearing on obesity.

Full Figure Potential: A Fat Girls Blues by Georgia Me

Out of money looking for a snack

Then I see little Debbie's face on a pack

Smiling, enticing me, inviting me to have a taste

With haste I race to the destruction of my waist

As the sugar sets in so does the disgust I feel

Wishing I had the power of will

Or hoping someone would kill this gluttonous monster which rules my eyes

Which is bigger than my stomach so we fill my belly with pies

And cakes, by-products, additives and other shit

It's hard for me to quit, sweets are a quick hit

My diet includes fried everything, all kinds of pork

People asking if I've been visited by the stork

See it's looked at as a sin to be fat without children or a medical condition

So it leaves a girl fishing, for an excuse to stop the

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abuse
I endure every day in every way through ridicule and personal shame
Unwanted attention and fame from the group of young men who holler "Big Drawers"
As I pass by I start to cry, the wind dries my eye
But nothing can heal this scar left on my esteem
Praying this order is a dream or better yet a nightmare
For it's too hard to bare this constant scar as my reality
A complete disregard for humanity
Not seen as human, more like insane or having no self control
She can't even pass up a jelly roll
Not seen as beautiful, look at the folds and gut the cellulite thighs and out of shape butt
Not seen as strong "She can't go long, she'll be down before the end of the song"
My personal demons are hard by themselves
Comparisons to pigs, elephants and whales
You might look at me and see lazy and weak

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Giving no second thought, that before you an angel may speak
You can't see the beauty besides the pretty face
You don't see the warmth of my heart which provides a safe place
Or a home where not only love roams
For myself and others which light has not been shown
See I realized, I'm more than a body, I have a spirit and a mind
Which through divine knowledge told me it's about time for me to love who I am
And decline those devils who try to steal my joy
I'm conquering my foes like Helen of Troy
And with the same spirit I make the world hear this
Love who you are be the best that you can be
Your spirit will soar and the whole world will see
Your strength, your beauty and your heart
The ignorance of others won't pierce like a dart
Let those who worship aesthetics live a pathetic life
No substance, no feelings, self-inflicted strife
If they can't see the beauty of my soul

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I know I'm beautiful in the eyes God beholds

See, I know at times I may get knocked down or even,
doubt my ability

But I'll look in the mirror and say I'm wonderful with
humility

Now we're supposed to respect everyone with different
choices, beliefs and hues

But who gives a damn about a fat girl's blues?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Georgia Me
Book: Russell Simmons Def Poetry Jam on Broadway
ISBN: 978-0743476225
Publisher: Simon and Schuster
Date (Month/Year): 2005

AWARD HISTORY

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INTRODUCTION

Obesity is the last frontier in tolerable prejudices, even against children. Discrimination based on age, race, religion, sexual preference and gender identity is illegal. However, it is not illegal to discriminate against people based on their weight. We do it every day.

Do you really think that the overweight person you see at the grocery store, at the mall or the restaurant WANTS to be that size? Do you really believe they haven't tried every diet on the market, considered surgery or even suicide to stop being the size they are? We are so quick to fat shame . . . Leaving those people who struggle praying for something different.

Pre-Flight Prayer of a Fat Girl by Rachel Wiley

Pray, let us be thankful for the well trained smile of the
flight attendant

it may be the only one pointed at us on this day

Let us not be embarrassed to request the seat belt
extender

but rather rejoice in its being.

Let us pray for a seat that sits not on an aisle

but a window so we may cling to the plane wall

in attempt to make ourselves small

enough

Let us also move our bodies as little as possible enduring

cramp and ache alike

so as not to be a burden unto our seatmate.

And blessed be that seatmate who does neither sigh nor scorn

when our hip sneaks over the line of the armrest

Yay, let us never book with SouthWest for they will

send us into exile

for not being fruitful and purchasing 2 seats to contain

our bounty when only 1 can be afforded.

Pray, let us ignore the glances when the pilot announces

the craft is overweight

and must sit flightless while luggage is rearranged for balance.

Lo, Let us not look to the magazine models tucked into

the seat backs like hymnals

as anything holy

Pray, let us remember we are beautiful in our bounty

Pray most of all that we forgive ourselves

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And smooth the creases of apology we have folded our

delicate bodies into on this day

Come home and stretch out across our beds like the

unpacking of a suitcase full of all the best souvenirs.

Our bones are racks of the kitschiest key chains.

Our bellies, magnificent snow globes.

Look and rejoice at everything we managed to get home safe.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rachel Wiley
Book: Fat Girl Finishing School
ISBN: 978-0989009225
Publisher: Timber Mouse
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2014

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*So . . . If people are so bothered by the stigma of being obese, why don't they just lose weight? As anyone with a history of dieting knows, it's extremely difficult to lose weight and even more difficult to keep it off. Sure, blaming the victim frees everyone else of responsibility. But my dream is that one day the great divide between the beautiful and the ugly will cease to be and people will be judged not for the **size** of their skin, but by the content of their character.*

Fat Girl by Melissa May

So the poet tells me, all cloaked in beautiful words and
authentic Albanian eyebrows
that she make clothes for bodies,
not bodies for clothes
My body sits folded in a wicker chair like
two pallets of rising dough.
I pray she can't see my navel tremble.

I tell her,
I have been the fat girl in over a dozen schools.

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I sit all token-like in their hall of fame, except --
they don't give awards to punch lines
So I repeat the code of conduct like a mantra, even
years
after the cap and gown have yellowed in the Oklahoma
Sun.

Do not like boys.
Do not go for seconds.
Do not draw attention.

See I know what a body feels like when it changes from
vessel
to funeral shrouds,
To sarcophagus.
I have been buried alive for so long,
I've forgotten what the sun
tastes like.

But they're allowed to hate me.
Even now, strangers on the street
Are allowed their sharp-tongue judgment, their sound
effects.

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Being this big is fuel for the last appropriate hate crime.

It is stand-up acceptable in its pretty designer suit—

Size medium, pressed in brand new shoes.

It's my fault.

I will never curve like a comma around the bodies

of people I am not allowed to love,

I'm supposed to settle for anyone who

can stomach my punctuation.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Melissa May
Book: SparkleFat
ISBN: 978-0692225417
Publisher: Words Dance Publishing
Date (Month/Year): May 2014

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